furthering his domestic objectives' [98] as he spoke of the need to 'build for an India of the twenty-first century'. [99] In his speech soon after his mother's assassination, Rajiv laid out the key principles of his foreign policy which reflected Nehruvianism by emphasizing non-alignment, anti-colonialism, adherence to multinational institutions like the United Nations and a desire for good relations with all countries. 'Jawaharlal Nehru bequeathed to us a foreign policy,' he said, adding, 'I shall carry it forward. I reaffirm our adherence to the United Nations, to the Nonaligned Movement and to our opposition to colonialism, old or new … We have always been friends with East and West as they are called and we want better relations with them.'[100]

A year later, in New York Rajiv stated that the basic principles of India's foreign policy were 'a logical outcome of our own experiences, needs and aspirations'. To him, standing with oppressed peoples was still important, as was the desire to resolve issues through peace. The streak of independence was important because India 'will not be a camp follower'. Sounding like Nehru, Rajiv stated in an interview on an American news show: 'We take a stand which is right.'[101] He also made it clear that he was seeking to create a balance between tradition and modernity. In his address before a joint session of the United States Congress on 13 June 1985, Rajiv spoke about India being an old country but a young nation. He emphasized the 'firm foundations' laid down by modern India's founders on which the future would be built. He spoke of the goal of a 'strong, independent and self-reliant' India.[102]

Rajiv's pragmatism was reflected in his desire to improve relations with Pakistan and China. In a speech given two weeks after the assassination of his mother, Rajiv emphasized that for him the first requisite for India's march forward was 'peace with our neighbours'.[103] In his inaugural address at the annual South Asian Association for Regional Conference (SAARC) Summit in 1986, Rajiv emphasized the importance of the geographical, historical, religio-cultural and ethnolinguistic ties that bound the various